



INAUGURAL KEYNOTE ADDRESS

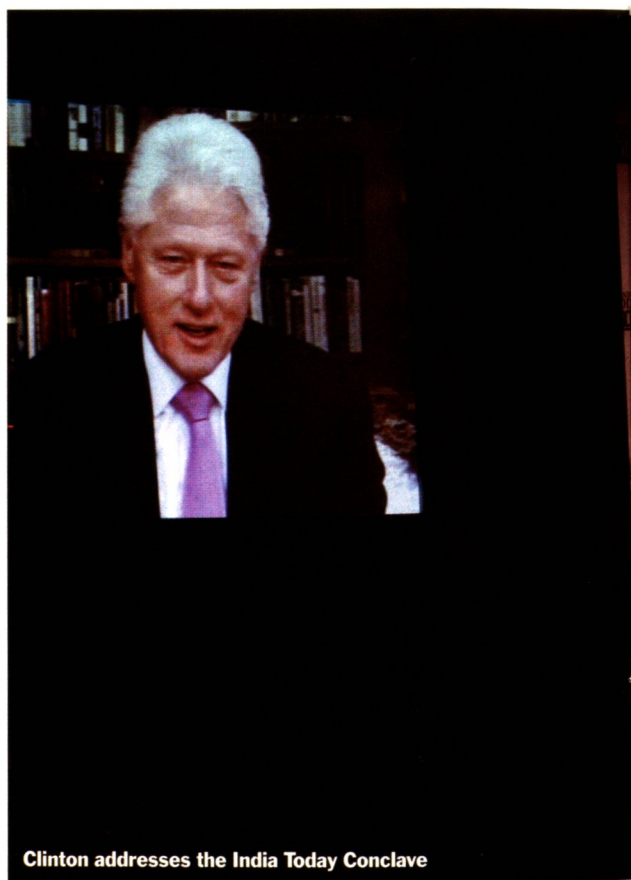
"We can't expect government to deal with all big challenges"

WILLIAM JEFFERSON CLINTON 42ND PRESIDENT OF USA

When I spoke at the INDIA TODAY Conclave in 2003, I had the opportunity to say that we should build a world of positive interdependence, not negative interdependence, and to do that we had to deal with the challenges of building shared opportunities. In the five years that have elapsed, as we look back we see an enormous amount of progress as well as significant and persistent peril, reminding us again that every nation and every region in this interdependent global environment is bedevilled by three problems.

The first is persistent, enduring inequality—inequality in employment and incomes, in access to education and health-care. The second is insecurity, which in the current circumstances of our interdependence means that we are open to forces beyond our borders, which include terror, the prospect of being exposed to dangerous nuclear and biological materials, and the danger of global epidemics like avian influenza. And finally, the course that we are on is unsustainable because of the undeniable reality of global warming which we see manifests over and over again in rapidly changing circumstances in the global environment.

So, as we look ahead, we can celebrate the last five years and what they have done for India. Look at the enormous burst of creativity, strength and economic and political influence in India; look at the generation of new wealth; look at the fact that India now has the world's largest middle class. But here you also see persistent inequality, continued sporadic violence and you have to face the fact that global warming requires us to change the trajectory of growth in terms of our energy usage. Can we do these things? Can the positive elements of the interdependent world of the 21st century outweigh the negative ones? That is the great overarching question of our time. A lot of the specific elements and questions have to be answered by our political leaders. I spend a lot of my time asking and trying to answer the question of what civil society can do. What can we do, those of us who are private citizens, who are not in political power and who will never be in political power but who have access to resources and human creativity? In a world where the non-governmental sector is more influential than ever before—you surely see this India where over half-a-million non-governmental organisations are operating in villages and are funded by very wealthy individuals—you see it all over the country and the United States



Clinton addresses the India Today Conclave

where a number of non-governmental groups have been established in this decade by people who believe that civil society can make a difference in tackling these big problems.

Let us just begin with the world health crisis. A quarter of all the people on earth this year will die of AIDS, TB, malaria and infections related to dirty water—diarrhoea, dysentery, cholera. Eighty per cent of the people in that category will be children under five. By and large these are the diseases of the poor. The diseases of the poor ram home